

Towards Scalable Reachability: Global Nonconvex Optimization of Viscous Hamilton-Jacobi PDEs

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Abstract—Computing safe reachable sets in verification settings for high-dimensional dynamic systems, parameterized by the viscous Hamilton-Jacobi (HJ) equation, in general involves grid discretization of the phase space to achieve a numerically consistent solution with respect to the original non-viscous problem. This presents a two-fold problem: discretization implies exponential memory requirements; and, computational costs increase as problem dimensions multiply. While parallel computing can reduce the impact of the latter, it does not address the grid discretization exponential memory costs of the former. Leveraging a recent connection between HJ value functions, proximity operators, and the Moreau envelopes of HJ PDEs, we cast the recovery of the safe set as an adaptive gradient descent optimization of the Moreau envelope of the reachable HJI variational PDE. Our scheme provides a storage-free means for resolving safe sets in a computationally time-efficient manner without dealing with the exponential memory costs of grid discretization.

I. INTRODUCTION

This paper takes a further step towards improved computational and scalable solutions to time-dependent Hamilton-Jacobi (HJ) partial differential equations (PDEs) [1] employed in the safety verification [2] of dynamical systems. We work within a viscous HJ reachability ramification [3]–[6] and establish our results with globally optimal solutions to the reachability problems in nonlinear settings. In emphasis, we consider the first-order nonlinear scalar Hamilton-Jacobi (HJ) PDEs of the form

$$\begin{aligned} v_t + H(t; x, \partial_x v) &= 0 \text{ in } \mathbb{R}^n \times (0, T] \\ v(x, 0) &= g(x) \text{ on } \mathbb{R}^n \times t = 0 \end{aligned} \quad (\text{HJ-IVP})$$

where v_t denotes the partial derivative of the vector field $v(x, t)$ with respect to t ; the Hamiltonian $H(x, t)$ is continuously defined on $\mathbb{R}^n$; $g(x)$ is bounded and uniformly continuous (BUC) in $\mathbb{R}^n$; and $\partial_x v$ is the spatial gradient of $v(x, t)$. While a unique C^2 solution $v(x, t)$ exists uniformly on $0 \leq t < T$ to (HJ-IVP) for which $\lim_{t \rightarrow T} v(x, t)$ (when H and g are smooth and $v_0(x, t)$ is compactly supported), $H(x, t)$ lacks continuous derivatives in this limit so that $\partial_x v$ vanishes at $t = T$.

However, one may find Lipschitz continuous functions $v(x, t)$ on $\mathbb{R}^n \times (0, T]$ which are smooth *almost everywhere* (a.e.) and satisfy (HJ-IVP) in a “generalized sense”. Suppose that we fix a positive $\delta > 0$, Crandall and Lions [7] showed

that if $\delta > 0$, then v^δ is the *vanishing viscosity* solution of

$$\begin{aligned} v_t^\delta + H(t; x, \nabla_x v^\delta) &= \frac{\delta}{2} \Delta v^\delta \text{ in } \mathbb{R}^n \times (0, T] \\ v^\delta(x, 0) &= g(x) \text{ on } \mathbb{R}^n \times t = 0 \end{aligned} \quad (\text{HJ-Viscous})$$

with Laplacian Δv^δ and a constant $k > 0$. Uniform convergence of $v^\delta \rightarrow v$ exists in the limit $\delta \rightarrow 0^+$, i.e.

$$\sup_{t \in (0, T)} \sup_{x \in \mathbb{R}^n} |v(x, t) - v^\delta(x, t)| \leq k\sqrt{\delta}. \quad (1)$$

Equation (HJ-Viscous) models conservation laws in a single spatial dimension [8]. For inf-sup or sup-inf optimal control problems [3], the Hamiltonian is related to the *backward* reachable set [4] of a dynamical system. Reachable systems are those where one can compute all states that can be reached from an initial condition in a *finite number of steps*.

Popular numerically consistent optimal solutions [7], [9] to (HJ-Viscous) utilize problem space grid discretization [4], [10]. However, these require exponential memory storage – making their practical applications limited for large problems. Our recent efforts [5], [6] leveraged single-instruction, multiple threads (SIMT) computing schemes on modern GPUs to accelerate computational times on a host of practical problems; we demonstrated improved scalability with up to 76 – 92% improvement in computational times on higher-dimensional problems. However, it was grid based and as problem dimensions increase, the need for more memory may make such approaches unattractive to users.

We thus tack another thread, jettisoning grid discretization methods for sampling-based proximal operators in a statistical moving average context. This resolves the global extrema of the Moreau envelopes of HJ equations and can be used to recover the reachable set in nonconvex optimization settings [11]–[14]. The Cole-Hopf transformation [1], [13] employed in PDE analysis relates the heat equation solution to that of the viscous HJ equation’s solution. Recently, Osher et. al [8] applied the Cole-Hopf transformation to v^δ and related the resulting transformed heat conservation equation to an importance sampling scheme for approximating the solution v^δ of (HJ-Viscous). We build on this, introducing an adaptive Moreau gradient descent for optimizing the value function under two inputs in a differential game setting. Ours is a sampling scheme that sidesteps essentially nonoscillatory [8] finite-differencing Lax-Friedrichs schemes [10] in favor of a gradient descent optimization on the Moreau envelope of the value function. This allows is to resolve

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robustly controlled backward reachable sets and tubes [15] in the terminal Hamilton-Jacobi-Isaacs equation [4], [5], [16].

The rest of this paper is structured as follows: in §II, we provide the theoretical machinery for our problem. In §III, we describe our methods. Section IV presents our numerical algorithms on sample problems and we conclude the paper in §V.

II. BACKGROUND

We first introduce the notations that are commonly throughout this article. Reachable sets within the context of two person games [16] and their accompanying “viscous” terminal HJI PDE [17] are then introduced. This is followed by the HJ-Isaacs PDEs commonly used to characterize reachable sets.

A. Notations and Terminologies

Conventions: Bold font upper-case and lower-case Roman letters are matrices and vectors, respectively; calligraphic letters are sets. Exception: the subdifferential set of a BUC function, $g(x)$, is denoted ∂ . Time variables e.g. t_0, t, τ, T will always be real positive numbers. The n -dimensional Euclidean space is $\mathbb{R}^n$; the set of natural numbers is $\mathbb{N}$. The natural log of T is denoted $\log T$. The dot product is $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$. The partial time derivative of v is ∂v_t while its partial spatial derivative is denoted ∂v_x . For a function $f(x(t), y(t))$ with every argument parameterized by t , we simply write $f(t; x, y)$. We represent the real-valued Hilbert space with $\mathcal{H}$; denote $2^{\mathcal{H}}$ by its power set, i.e. the family of all subsets of $\mathcal{H}$. Associated with $\mathcal{H}$ is the maximally monotone set-valued operator, $Q : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow 2^{\mathcal{H}}$. The zeroes of Q are denoted $\text{zer } Q = \{x \in \mathcal{H} \mid 0 \in Qx\}$. The set of global minimizers of $g(x)$ is denoted $\text{Argmin } g(x)$. It is written as $\text{argmin } g(x)$ when the set is a singleton. The set of fixed point of operator $S : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow \mathcal{H}$ is $\text{Fix } S = \{x \in \mathcal{H} \mid Sx = x\}$.

The unique solution $x \in \mathbb{R}^n$ of the dynamical system $\dot{x}(\tau) = f(t; x, u, w)$ is influenced by a pursuing player P (with control $w \in \mathcal{W} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^p$) and its evading pair E (with control $u \in \mathcal{U} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^m$). System trajectories $\xi_{x,\tau}^{u,w}$ emanate from $\dot{x}(\tau)$ by minimizing a scalar-valued objective

$$\mathcal{J}(\tau; x, u, w) = \min_{\tau \in [t, T]} g(\xi_{x,\tau}^{u,w}(\tau)) \quad (\text{Target set cost})$$

within a two-person differential game for a fixed $T \geq \tau > t$. The controllers belong in compact sets which are measurable functions

$$\bar{U} \equiv u : [t, T] \rightarrow \mathcal{U}, \quad \bar{W} \equiv w : [t, T] \rightarrow \mathcal{W}. \quad (2)$$

B. Lower value of the differential game

For a (possibly infinite) terminal time T , a constant k , $u \in \mathcal{U}$, $w \in \mathcal{W}$ and all $\hat{x}$, $x \in \mathbb{R}^n$, let the system possess a BUC payoff functional $g(x(T))$ that satisfies $g : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. The differential game’s lower value [18]

$$v^-(x, t) = \inf_{\beta \in \mathcal{B}(t)} \sup_{u \in \mathcal{U}(t)} \mathcal{J}(t; x, u, w) \quad (3a)$$

$$\triangleq \inf_{\beta \in \mathcal{B}(t)} \sup_{u \in \mathcal{U}(t)} \min_{\tau \in [t, T]} g(\xi_{x,\tau}^{u,w}(\tau)). \quad (3b)$$

is the viscosity solution to (HJ-IVP) [18, Lemma 2.1] with Hamiltonian,

$$H^-(t, x, u, w, p) = \max_{u \in \mathcal{U}} \min_{w \in \mathcal{W}} \langle f(t, x, u, w), p \rangle. \quad (4)$$

Notice in (3a) that the pursuer possesses a non-anticipative strategy $\mathcal{B}(t)$ that is aware of all (maximizing) controls of the evading player up until time t . In what follows, we drop the negative superscript to refer to the value of the game in the context of reachability analysis.

C. Robustly Controlled Backward Reachable Set and Tube

Suppose that the goal of E is to reach a user-specified target region $\mathcal{L}_0(\tau)$ within $\tau \leq T$ time steps of playing the game; while the P simultaneously seeks to prevent this from happening. Since we are in a two-player best-response scenario, the invariant set $\mathcal{L}_0$ obtained at T

$$\mathcal{L}_0(T) = \{x \in \mathbb{R}^n \mid g(0; x) \leq 0\} \quad (\text{Target-Set})$$

is “robustly controlled” for the “distance-to-target-set” cost $g(0; x)$, with constraints $|g(0; x)| \leq k$, $|g(0; x) - g(t; \hat{x})| \leq k|x - \hat{x}|$ where $k > 0$ is a constant, and all $-T \leq t \leq 0$, $\{\hat{x}, x \in \mathbb{R}^n\}$ ¹. The distance to $\mathcal{L}_0(\tau)$ is typically found by optimizing $g(x, t)$ as in (Target set cost). The HJI PDE (3a) and Hamiltonian (4) for this set admit the form

$$\begin{aligned} v_t(t; x) + \min\{0, H(x, \partial v_x(t; x))\} &= 0, \\ v(0; x) &= g(0; x). \end{aligned} \quad (\text{HJI-RCBRT})$$

For the safety problem setup in (3a), the corresponding robustly controlled backward reachable tube (RCBRT) on $(0, T]$ is the closure of the open set [15]

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{L}([\tau, 0], \mathcal{L}_0) &= \{x \in \mathbb{R}^n \mid \exists \beta \in \bar{\mathcal{W}}(t) \forall u \in \mathcal{U}(t), \exists \\ &\tau \in [-T, 0], \xi(\bar{t}) \in \mathcal{L}_0\}. \end{aligned} \quad (\text{Target-Tube})$$

Read: The set of states from which the strategies of P and for all controls of E imply that we reach and remain in the target set in the interval $[-T, 0]$. Following Lemma 2 of [4], the states in the reachable set admit the following properties w.r.t the value function v^- :

$$\begin{aligned} x(t) \in \mathcal{L}(\cdot) &\implies v(x, t) \leq 0, \\ v(x, t) \leq 0 &\implies x(t) \in \mathcal{L}(\cdot). \end{aligned} \quad \begin{aligned} (5a) \\ (\text{Zero Levelset}) \end{aligned}$$

In backward reach avoid tubes where the agent must avoid the unsafe region at all times, we can write (HJI-RCBRT) as the HJI variational inequality for a robustly controlled backward reach-avoid tube (RCBRAT) as follows,

$$\begin{aligned} \min\{v_t(t; x) + H(t; x, \partial v_x), g(x, t) - v(t; x)\} &\leq 0, \\ v(0; x) &= g(0; x). \end{aligned} \quad (\text{HJI-RCBRAT})$$

Challenges in optimizing the RCBRT/RCBRAT: Computing the RCBRT presents a host of challenges for optimization because (a) the dynamics $f(\cdot)$ is usually nonlinear with coupled states in most problems of interest; (b) although $\mathcal{L}([\tau, 0], \mathcal{L}_0)$ is mostly smooth, it possesses discontinuous

¹Time is reversed in BRT computational scenarios.

“shocks” at solution crossover points (see [15]); this makes global gradient-based optimization impossible for resolving v ; (c) more than one trajectory can emanate from the RCBRT’s boundary that end up at the same point on the target set – this makes sampling-based optimization difficult, but not insurmountable; and (d) the RCBRT is nonconvex.

To mitigate these challenges above, we introduce a set of tools that allow us to circumvent these challenges in an optimization context.

D. Cole-Hopf Transformation and the Heat Equation

For the BUC function $g(t; x) : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ from (HJ-IVP), consider the transformation $\varphi^\delta(x) = \exp(-v^\delta/\delta)$ originally attributed to Cole and Hopf [1, §4.4.1]. Applying the Cole-Hopf transformation to (HJ-Viscous), we can write

$$\begin{aligned} \partial \varphi_t^\delta(x, t) - \frac{\delta}{2} \varphi^\delta(x, t) &= 0 \text{ in } \mathbb{R}^n \times (0, T] \\ \varphi^\delta(x, t) &= \exp(-g/\delta) \text{ on } \mathbb{R}^n \times \{t = 0\}^2. \end{aligned} \quad (\text{Heat-Kernel})$$

The fundamental solution, $\Phi_{\delta t}$ to (Heat-Kernel) at time t is [1]

$$\Phi_{\delta t}(x) = \begin{cases} (2\pi\delta t)^{n/2} \exp\left(-\frac{|x|^2}{2\delta t}\right) & \text{in } \mathbb{R}^n \times (0, T], \\ 0 & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

The heat equation (Heat-Kernel) admits the following explicit formulae (as a convolution, an integral expression, and a Gaussian expectation; see derivation in [11, Appendix B]),

$$\varphi^\delta(t; x) = (\Phi_{\delta t} \star \exp(-g/\delta))(x), \quad (6a)$$

$$\equiv \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} (\Phi_{\delta t}(x - y) \exp(-g(y)/\delta)) dy, \quad (6b)$$

$$= \mathbb{E}_{y \sim \mathcal{N}(x, \delta t)} [\exp(-\delta^{-1} g(y))]. \quad (6c)$$

The equation (Heat-Kernel) transforms solutions to the heat equation [1], [12] to those of the viscous HJ PDE. It has enjoyed use in studying the energy landscape of neural networks [13], [19] and viscous HJ loss functions [11]. Inspecting (Heat-Kernel), we may write

$$g^\delta(x) := v^\delta(t; x) \quad (7a)$$

$$= -\delta \log(\varphi^\delta(t; x))(x) \text{ in } \mathbb{R}^n \times (0, T], \quad (7b)$$

from which we can write

$$\partial v_x^\delta(t; x) = -\delta \cdot \frac{\partial \varphi_x^\delta(t; x)}{\varphi^\delta(t; x)}. \quad (8)$$

Chaudhari et al. [13] called $g^\delta(x)$ the local entropy and postulated a stochastic differential equation (SDE) scheme that leverages $g^\delta(x)$ in SGD contexts in resolving the viscous HJ PDE. Recent publications treat HJ PDE optimization [12] in light of this local entropy function by combining Moreau envelopes [20] and proximal operator [21] algorithmics to establish zero-order optimization schemes for the viscous HJ loss function (with guaranteed convergence to global optima).

III. METHODS

We now cast the computation of the optimal “controllable”³ reachable set into a form that leverages the Moreau envelope (Moreau-Env) in a successive approximation scheme so that the reachable set can be obtained via the subdifferential operator of the problem.

A. Operators and Envelopes of HJ Equations

Monotone operator theory has had a huge impact on partial differential equations and nonlinear systems [22], [23], reducing nonlinear analyses to problems of the form

$$\text{determine } x \in \text{zer } Q = \{x \in \mathcal{H} \mid 0 \in Qx\}. \quad (9)$$

The subdifferential operator (see [21, §16]), $\partial g : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow 2^{\mathcal{H}}$, of $g(x)$ at $\bar{x}$ is the set of all ϑ that satisfies

$$\{\vartheta \in \mathcal{H} \mid (\forall x \in \mathcal{H}) \langle x - \bar{x}, \vartheta \rangle + g(\bar{x}) \leq g(x)\}. \quad (10)$$

That is, g is subdifferentiable at x if $\partial g(x) \neq \emptyset$; hence, elements of $\partial g(x)$ are the subgradients of g at x .

An optimization implication of (10) is Fermat’s rule, which states that for $g : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow (0, T)$ [24],

$$\text{argmin } g = \text{zer } \partial g. \quad (11)$$

The proximity operator of $g(x)$ at a time, $t \in (0, T]$ is the minimizers set [25]

$$\text{Prox}_{tg}(x) \triangleq \arg \min_{z \in \mathcal{H}} \left(g(z) + \frac{1}{2t} \|z - x\|^2 \right) \quad (\text{Prox-Op})$$

that define the Moreau envelope $v(\cdot, t)$, defined as [20]

$$v(x, t) = \min_{z \in \mathcal{H}} \left(g(z) + \frac{1}{2t} \|z - x\|^2 \right). \quad (\text{Moreau-Env})$$

The envelope v expands troughs of $g(x)$ and its local minimizers concur with those of g [13].

Lemma 1: Suppose that $g(x)$ is BUC, its subdifferential exists, the set $\mathcal{S}_\alpha \triangleq \{z \in \mathbb{R}^n : g(z) \leq \inf g + \alpha\}$ is compact, $\text{zer } \partial g$ exists and $x \in \mathcal{S}_\alpha$. An important result established in [11, Lemma A.3] relates the spatial gradients of the solution to (HJ-IVP) to the proximity operator of $g(x)$ at time t as

$$\text{Prox}_{tg}(x) = x - t \partial v_x(t; x) \approx x - t \cdot \partial v_x^\delta(t; x). \quad (12)$$

Our goal now is to leverage the Proximity operator in the minimization (Target set cost) while playing the zero-sum two-player differential game (HJI-RCBRAT) to optimize for the RCBRT (Target-Tube) and the zero levelset (5). In this light, we can replace $v(x, t)$ (HJ-IVP) by its viscous and smooth proxy (HJ-Viscous), evaluate the minimizer (Target set cost) using the proximal operator result (1) and solve for the inf-sup optimal control problem in (3a).

³We use this term because the agents in the differential game system have control inputs

B. The Kernel of the HJ PDE and its proximity operator

Consider the kernel $\varphi^\delta(\mathbf{x}, t)$ in (Heat-Kernel) which corresponds to the solution of (HJ-Viscous). Resolving the convolution (6) is intractable for large n and time step t . However, it is same as the probability density of a Gaussian distribution with mean $\mathbf{x}$ and variance δt (as derived in [11, Appendix B]), i.e.

$$\partial \varphi^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}) = -\frac{1}{\delta t} \cdot \mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{y} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{x}, \delta t)} [(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}) \exp(\mathbf{g}(\mathbf{y})/\delta)]. \quad (13)$$

Plugging (6c) and (13) into (8), we find that

$$t \cdot \partial \mathbf{v}_\mathbf{x}^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{x} - \frac{\mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{y} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{x}, \delta t)} [\mathbf{y} \exp(-\mathbf{g}(\mathbf{y})/\delta)]}{\mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{y} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{x}, \delta t)} [\exp(-\delta^{-1} \mathbf{g}(\mathbf{y}))]} \quad (14)$$

provides the time-scaled spatial gradients of $\mathbf{v}(t; \mathbf{x})$ in (17) without the need for unstable schemes employed in upwind methods within grid discretization numerical reachable sets' computational algorithms [5], [6], [26].

Substituting the r.h.s of (14) into (1), we find that

Proximal Operator for $\partial \mathbf{v}^\delta(t; \mathbf{x})$

$$\text{Prox}_{t\mathbf{g}}(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{\mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{y} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{x}, \delta t)} [\mathbf{y} \cdot \exp(-\mathbf{g}(\mathbf{y})/\delta)]}{\mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{y} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{x}, \delta t)} [\exp(-\delta^{-1} \mathbf{g}(\mathbf{y}))]} \quad (15)$$

C. Hamilton-Jacobi-Proximity Operator Relation

Now consider the HJ PDEs (HJI-RCBRT) and (HJI-RCBRAT) in light of (15). We can write the domain of these PDEs in light of the proximal expression (15) as

$$\begin{aligned} \partial \mathbf{v}_t(t; \mathbf{x}) + \min\{0, \mathbf{H}(t; \mathbf{x}, \partial \mathbf{v}_\mathbf{x}(t; \mathbf{x}))\} &= 0, \\ \approx \partial \mathbf{v}_t^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}) + \min\{0, \mathbf{H}^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}, \partial \mathbf{v}_\mathbf{x}^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}))\} &= 0, \\ := \partial \mathbf{v}_t^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}) + \min \left\{ 0, \max_{\mathbf{u} \in \mathcal{U}} \min_{\mathbf{w} \in \mathcal{W}} \left\langle f(t; \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w}), \right. \right. \\ &\quad \left. \left. \frac{1}{t}(\mathbf{x} - \text{Prox}_{t\mathbf{g}}(\mathbf{x})) \right\rangle \right\} = 0, \end{aligned} \quad (16)$$

for (HJI-RCBRT). Similarly, the right-hand-side of the variational inequality for (HJI-RCBRAT) can be written as

$$\begin{aligned} \min\{\partial \mathbf{v}_t(t; \mathbf{x}) + \mathbf{H}(t; \mathbf{x}, \partial \mathbf{v}_\mathbf{x}), \mathbf{g}(\mathbf{x}, t) - \mathbf{v}(t; \mathbf{x})\}, \\ \approx \min\{\partial \mathbf{v}_t^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}) + \mathbf{H}^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}, \partial \mathbf{v}_\mathbf{x}^\delta), \mathbf{g}(\mathbf{x}, t) - \mathbf{v}^\delta(t; \mathbf{x})\}, \\ := \min\{\partial \mathbf{v}_t^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}) + \max_{\mathbf{u} \in \mathcal{U}} \min_{\mathbf{w} \in \mathcal{W}} \langle f(t; \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w}), \partial \mathbf{v}_\mathbf{x}^\delta, \\ \mathbf{g}(t; \mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{v}^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}) \rangle\}. \end{aligned} \quad (17)$$

Thus, evaluating the spatial gradient of $\mathbf{v}^\delta$ in (17) amounts to drawing samples using the proximity expression above and using (6c) to evaluate $\mathbf{v}^\delta$. We can now write (HJI-RCBRAT)

Algorithm 1 Sampling-based RCBRT descent.

Given $\{\epsilon, \delta\} > 0$, and initial step size α .
function **ProxReach**($\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{g}, \eta, t_0, T$) $\triangleright$ Sample size, η .
 Set $\tau = t_0, t_s = (T - t_0)/k$.
while $T - \tau > \epsilon T$ **do**
 $\mathbf{y}[\tau] \leftarrow \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{x}, \delta)$ $\triangleright$ Draw finite samples from $\mathbf{x}$.
 $\mathbf{z}[\tau] \leftarrow \mathbf{g}(\mathbf{y}[\tau]);$ $\triangleright$ See equation (7).
 $\partial \mathbf{z} \mathbf{v}(\tau; \mathbf{z}) \leftarrow \text{Prox}_{\tau \mathbf{g}}(\mathbf{z}, \delta)$ $\triangleright$ Eq. (Prox-Op).
 $\tau \leftarrow \tau + t_s$
 $\mathbf{z}[\tau + t_s] \leftarrow \mathbf{z}[\tau] - \alpha \cdot \mathbf{g}[\tau]$
 $\tau \leftarrow \text{Adjuster}(\tau, \mathbf{g}[\tau], \mathbf{g}[\tau - \Delta t])$
end while
end function

as

$$\min \left\{ \partial \mathbf{v}_t^\delta(t; \mathbf{x}) + \max_{\mathbf{u} \in \mathcal{U}} \min_{\mathbf{w} \in \mathcal{W}} \left\langle f(t; \mathbf{x}, \mathbf{u}, \mathbf{w}), \frac{1}{t}(\mathbf{x} - \text{Prox}_{t\mathbf{g}}(\mathbf{x})) \right\rangle \right\}, \quad (18a)$$

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{g}(\mathbf{x}, t) + \delta \log \mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{y} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{x}, \delta t)} [\exp(-\delta^{-1} \mathbf{g}(\mathbf{y}))] \Big\} &\leq 0 \\ \mathbf{v}(0; \mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{g}(0; \mathbf{x}). \end{aligned} \quad (18b)$$

D. Problem Algorithmics

We now cast the solution of the variational HJI computational problem as a Monte Carlo algorithmics. Towards finding global solutions to the optimization problem, we adapt the Hamilton-Jacobi Moreau adaptive descent algorithm of [11] to the computation of the HJI(HJI-RCBRT) and (HJI-RCBRAT).

The Moreau adaptive descent algorithm works by minimizing the Moreau envelope (Moreau-Env) of the HJ PDE in a nonconvex optimization scheme via a zeroth-order sampling scheme. In its native form, within a set convergence loop, it works by

- first computing the spatial gradient of $\mathbf{v}^\delta(t; \mathbf{x})$; then
- updating the states of the dynamic system in a gradient descent scheme (under an appropriate step size); and lastly
- uses an adaptive forward-backward time-update scheme to update the index of time.

The algorithm is succinctly described in Algorithm 1. Given a large initial step size α , time interval $(t_0, T]$ and the state values for a given problem $\mathbf{x}$, the algorithm proceeds in a reactive sampling-based gradient descent fashion by drawing finite samples of size η from the (potentially large) state space $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. The samples on Line 5 are drawn from a multinomial Gaussian filter for a total of η samples whose mean and variance are $\mathbf{x}$ and δt , respectively in every iteration of the algorithm. Within line 7, the Hamiltonian for the system is computed but negated to make the computational scheme conform to the backward reachable setting (since the iterative loop proceeds forward in the index of time in 1). In all our implementations, the time index within the

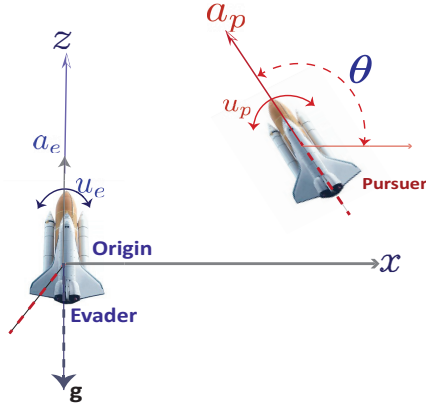


Fig. 1. Motion of two rockets on a Cartesian xz -plane with a thrust inclination in relative coordinates given by $\theta := u_p - u_e$.

loop is adaptively adjusted based on a version of the Armijo-Goldstein condition [27] to ensure that an appropriate time step is taken in every iteration as we seek the minimum value of the Moreau envelope.

After convergence, the solution(s) $\{x\}$ that minimize the value function are returned. We now adopt the HJ-MAD algorithm to the resolution of HJ problems with adversarial control inputs in a two-player differential game. This is delineated in Algorithm 1. After the optimization of the extrema of the value function, finding the safe set is equivalent to executing a search algorithm within the optimized value function to evaluate where the condition (5) are fulfilled. In the next section, we will connect the scheme we have presented so far to the safe reachability resolution problem of two rockets on a cartesian grid as originally used in our previous paper [5].

IV. NUMERICAL RESULTS

In this section, we provide a representative problem and amend it to the viscous HJI PDE (**HJI-RCBRT**) to test and verify our hypothesis.

A. The Rockets Launch Problem

We consider the rocket launch problem of Dreyfus [28] which was amended to a differential game between two identical rockets, P and E , on an (x, z) cross-section of a Cartesian plane in [5], [6]. We want to compute the usable part [16] or RCBRT [4] of the *approximate* terminal surface's boundary for a predefined target set over a target tube. The usable part entails the regions of the state-space for which the min-max operation over either strategy of P and E is below zero and where the boundary of the usable part (BUP) constitute where (**HJI-RCBRAT**) is exactly zero.

For a two-player differential game, let P and E share identical dynamics in a general sense so that we can freely choose the coordinates of P ; however, E 's origin is a distance Φ away from (x, z) at plane's origin (see Fig. 1) so that the PE vector's inclination measured counterclockwise from the x axis is θ .

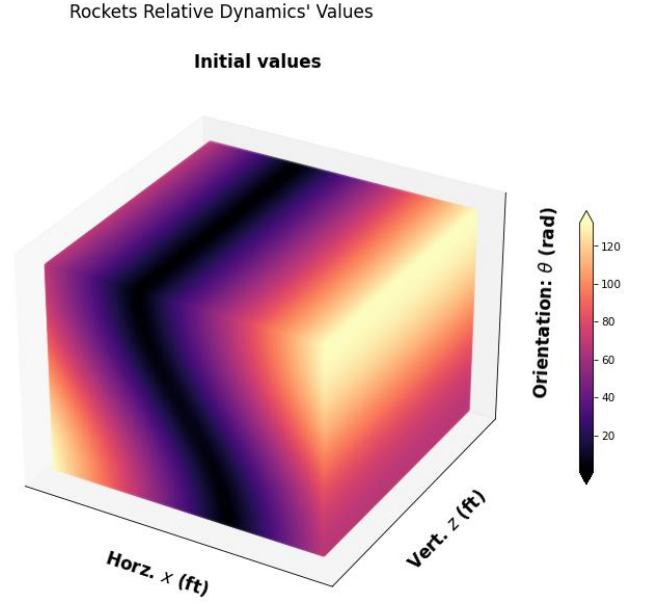


Fig. 2. Representation of the initial values as a heat map for the two rockets described in Fig. 1 and (24).

Hence, we may consider the current problem as a terminal pursuit-evasion *differential* game, whereupon the game terminates when *capture* occurs. This eventual terminal represents the final *overapproximated* (non)-capture surface for the $P-E$ game (to be shortly introduced). We desire that every $\max$ and $\min$ operations during a *game of kind* are in the interior of the plane where motion exists; this way, no sudden changes from extremes are too aggravating in cost.

Let the states of P and E be (x_p, x_e) , respectively, driven by thrusts (u_p, u_e) respectively (see Figure 1). Fix the rockets' range so that what is left of the motion of either P or E 's is restricted to orientation on the (x, z) plane as illustrated in Fig. 1, where a and g are respectively the acceleration and gravitational accelerations (in feet per square second)⁴. As long as E remains within this target region or *backward reachable tube* (or BRT), P cannot cause damage or exercise an action of deleterious consequence on, say, the territory being guarded by E . Setting up E to maximize a payoff quantity with the largest possible margin or at least frustrate the efforts of P with minimal collateral damage while the pursuer minimizes this quantity constitutes a terminal value *optimal* differential game: there is no optimal pursuit without an optimal evasion.

The motion of P relative to E 's along the (x, z) plane includes the relative orientation, the control input, shown in Fig. 1 as $\theta = u_p - u_e$. Following the conventions in Fig. 1, the game's relative equations of motion in *reduced space* [16, §2.2] was derived as (see [5, §VI.A]) is $x = (x, z, \theta)$ where

⁴We set $a = 1\text{ft}/\text{sec}^2$ and $g = 32\text{ft}/\text{sec}^2$ in our simulation.

$\theta \in [-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2})$ and $(x, z) \in \mathbb{R}^2$ are

$$\dot{\mathbf{x}} = \begin{cases} \dot{x} &= a_p \cos \theta + u_e x, \\ \dot{z} &= a_p \sin \theta + a_e + u_e x - g, \\ \dot{\theta} &= u_p - u_e. \end{cases} \quad (19)$$

The capture radius of the origin-centered circle Φ (we set $g = 1.5$ ft) is $\|\mathbf{PE}\|_2$ so that $g^2 = x^2 + z^2$. All capture points are specified by the variational HJ PDE [4]:

$$\frac{\partial g}{\partial t}(\mathbf{x}, t) + \min \left[0, \mathbf{H} \left(\mathbf{x}, \frac{\partial g(\mathbf{x}, t)}{\partial \mathbf{x}} \right) \right] \leq 0, \quad (20)$$

with Hamiltonian given by

$$\mathbf{H}(\mathbf{x}, p) = - \max_{u_e \in [\underline{u}_e, \bar{u}_e]} \min_{u_p \in [\underline{u}_p, \bar{u}_p]} \begin{bmatrix} p_1 & p_2 & p_3 \\ a_p \cos \theta + u_e x \\ a_p \sin \theta + a_e + u_p x - g \\ u_p - u_e \end{bmatrix}. \quad (21)$$

Here, p are the co-states, and $[\underline{u}_e, \bar{u}_e]$ denotes extremals that the evader must choose as input in response to the extremal controls that the pursuer plays i.e. $[\underline{u}_p, \bar{u}_p]$. Rather than resort to analytical *geometric reasoning*, we may analyze possibilities of behavior by either agent via a principled numerical simulation. This is the essence of this work. From (21), set $\underline{u}_e = \underline{u}_p = \underline{u} \triangleq -1$ and $\bar{u}_p = \bar{u}_e = \bar{u} \triangleq +1$ so that $\mathbf{H}(\mathbf{x}, p)$ is

$$\begin{aligned} & - \max_{u_e \in [\underline{u}_e, \bar{u}_e]} \min_{u_p \in [\underline{u}_p, \bar{u}_p]} \begin{bmatrix} p_1(a_p \cos \theta + u_e x) + \\ p_2(a_p \sin \theta + a_e + \\ u_p x - g) + p_3(u_p - u_e) \end{bmatrix} \\ & \triangleq -ap_1 \cos \theta - p_2(g - a - a \sin \theta) - \bar{u}|p_1 x + p_3| \\ & \quad + \underline{u}|p_2 x + p_3|, \end{aligned} \quad (22)$$

where the last line follows from setting $a_e = a_p \triangleq a$.

Thus, the rockets HJI equation (20) becomes

$$\partial_t g(t; \mathbf{x}) + \min [0, (-ap_1 \cos \theta - p_2(g - a - a \sin \theta) - |p_1 x + p_3| - |p_2 x + p_3|)] \leq 0, \quad (23)$$

where p_1, p_2, p_3 are the coefficients of the co-states obtained from (17). A similar derivation can be obtained for the (HJI-RCBRAT). The initial values of the game is as illustrated in Fig. 2.

B. Numerical Integration Considerations

We take the infinitesimal physics problem above and make it algorithmic first by discretizing the spatial and temporal domains i.e.

$$(x, z) \in (-100, +100], \theta \in (-\pi/2, \pi/2], t \in (0, 1], \quad (24)$$

with 1000 points along the temporal dimension and $\mathbf{x}_k - \mathbf{x}_{k-1} = 1/100$ along the spatial dimensions, where $k \in \mathbb{N}$. All our codes are implemented in pytorch, that runs on an Azure Linux node with the cpu processor specification: Intel Xeon Silver 4208 at 2.1GHz and 65GB memory; The pytorch runs on a Ubuntu 22.04 operating system.

We defined the target set as the top-left corner of the state space Fig. 2 and then run the Algorithm 1 on a time range of $(0, 1]$ seconds; we chose Dirichlet boundary conditions

$$\mathbf{v}^\delta(0; \mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{g}(0; \mathbf{x}) \triangleq 0. \quad (25)$$

The spatial gradients (co-states) were computed using the transformation (15) which were then used in generating the Hamiltonian and subsequently the solution to the safe set using (20).

V. CONCLUDE

We have presented a gradient-based nonconvex optimization scheme for computing the safe set of a two-person differential game. The gradient scheme is a zero order Moreau envelope optimization scheme whose extrema coincides with that of the HJ-Isaacs equation (which is non-convex in its Hamiltonian). We provided a means to optimize the Proximal operator of the Moreau envelope by adapting the [11] algorithm and we note that once this extrema is found, determining the safe set amounts to searching within the resulting optimized terminal values of the HJI equation to see where the conditions of (5) are fulfilled. We demonstrated a proof of concept with the relative motion of two rockets on a Cartesian grid where both players have control inputs: the evading player must avoid the pursuing player within a pre-specified time range while the pursuing player must try to capture the evader within the given time by maximizing time. In a best response strategy, each player responds to the control input of its adversarial player in a best-response strategy. Our results demonstrate the feasibility of our approach.

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